# Battle Card: Fourth / HotSchedules

**Competitor:** Fourth / HotSchedules (fourth.com) — Enterprise hospitality WFM platform with integrated ATS
**Target segment:** Restaurant chains, hotel groups, enterprise multi-site operators (500+ locations)
**Geography:** US, UK, Europe
**Pricing:** Enterprise/custom; not publicly disclosed

## Overview

Fourth (incorporating HotSchedules) is the dominant enterprise WFM platform for multi-site restaurant and hotel operators. Its ATS is an integrated module within the broader workforce, payroll, and HR platform. The UK ATS module receives active development (documented release notes Jan 2024). Strong in PEO arrangements and labour forecasting. ATS is clearly secondary to WFM — not a hiring-first product.

## Head-to-Head Comparison

| Feature | Fourth/HotSchedules | Lapam-ATS | Who Wins |
|---|---|---|---|
| **WFM/scheduling integration** | **Native — labour forecasting tied to hiring demand; post-hire scheduling seamless** | ⚠ External handoff — Deputy/7shifts integration (roadmap: 3 months post-launch) | **Fourth — if you need integrated WFM + ATS in one platform** |
| **Labour forecasting + headcount planning** | **Unique strength — labour forecasting tightly coupled with headcount planning** | Not in scope — Lapam-ATS is ATS-only | **Fourth — unique feature in the market** |
| **Pricing & accessibility** | Enterprise/custom pricing; excludes mid-market operators | **£300–600/month for 5–50 locations; transparent location-based pricing** | **Lapam-ATS — 10x more accessible for mid-market** |
| **Standalone ATS vs bundled platform** | ⚠ ATS is bundled with WFM, payroll, HR — requires full platform adoption | **ATS-only; hands off to Deputy, 7shifts, Sage, Xero — keep existing tools** | **Lapam-ATS — if you don't want to replace your entire WFM stack** |
| **Candidate sourcing & mobile UX** | ⚠ Sourcing and candidate-facing experience are weak (research: not a documented strength) | **Mobile-first no-login application; QR code apply; automated acknowledgement within 2 minutes** | **Lapam-ATS — better candidate engagement** |
| **Seasonal talent pool CRM** | Not present | **Core feature — batch re-engagement, talent pool consent lifecycle** | **Lapam-ATS — only hospitality ATS with this feature** |
| **UK compliance (RTW, GDPR)** | PEO compliance wrapper; UK ATS actively developed (Jan 2024 release notes) | **GBG IDVT integration, immutable audit records, GDPR consent as first-class entity** | Tie — both credible in UK market |
| **Implementation complexity** | ⚠ Enterprise deployment; slow adoption of new modules in large accounts | **Self-service onboarding in under 30 minutes; no training webinar required** | **Lapam-ATS — faster time-to-value** |

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|---|---|---|---|
| | (research) | | |

## When Fourth Wins

- **Enterprise scale:** 500+ location chains with dedicated TA teams, enterprise budgets, and existing WFM contracts
- **Integrated WFM suite requirement:** Operators who need recruitment, scheduling, time tracking, labour forecasting, and payroll in one platform
- **Labour forecasting:** Operators who forecast labour needs and want hiring demand to flow directly from scheduling and revenue projections — this is Fourth's unique strength
- **PEO/complex employment arrangements:** Fourth's PEO compliance wrapper is well-suited to regulated hiring in the UK
- **Existing Fourth contract:** If the operator is already on HotSchedules and satisfied, adding the ATS module is the path of least resistance

## When Lapam-ATS Wins

- **Mid-market pricing constraint:** Operators with £300–600/month budget who cannot justify enterprise pricing and don't need the full WFM platform
- **Standalone ATS need:** Operators who already use Deputy, 7shifts, Sage, or Xero and just need an ATS that hands off cleanly — not a bundled platform that requires ripping out existing tools
- **Seasonal operations:** Coastal hotels, ski resorts, event venues — any operator who re-hires the same population year after year. Fourth has no seasonal CRM.
- **Hiring-first focus:** Operators who want a tool optimised for candidate engagement and speed-to-hire, not a WFM platform with ATS as an afterthought
- **Implementation speed:** Operators who need to be live within 30 minutes of signing up, not 3 months of enterprise deployment

**Key positioning message: "An ATS that solves your hiring problem — not a £100K+ workforce platform you don't need yet."**

## Proof Points

### Pricing & Market Exclusion

Fourth pricing is enterprise/custom and not publicly disclosed. Research notes: "Enterprise pricing and complexity exclude the mid-market." Lapam-ATS targets £300–600/month for 5–50 locations — within discretionary budget for mid-market operators.

Source: Competitors.md; positioning framework

### ATS as Afterthought

Research: "ATS is clearly secondary to WFM — not a hiring-first product. Feature set is broad but sourcing and candidate experience are weak." The vacancy dashboard is improving (Jan 2024 release notes) but candidate-facing UX is not a documented strength.

Source: Competitors.md; Fourth product documentation

### Bundled Platform Constraint

Fourth is sold as an integrated WFM + ATS + payroll + HR platform. Operators cannot adopt the ATS module standalone — they must commit to the full platform. This creates switching cost and excludes operators who already use Deputy, 7shifts, Sage, or Xero and are satisfied with those tools.

Source: Competitors.md; product positioning analysis

### Seasonal CRM Gap

Fourth has no seasonal talent pool CRM feature. Claire persona (6 coastal properties): "I spent three weeks last March manually ringing through a spreadsheet of 200 people I hired two years ago." Lapam-ATS is the only hospitality ATS with batch re-engagement and talent pool consent lifecycle.

Source: ICP-and-personas.md; competitive analysis

## Objection Handling

### Objection: "We already use HotSchedules for scheduling. Why wouldn't we just add the ATS module?"

**Response:** "That's a fair question — and if you're happy with HotSchedules and the ATS module meets your hiring needs, that's probably the simplest path. But many operators we talk to tell us two things: one, they didn't realise Fourth's ATS module was an option because it's not sold separately; and two, when they evaluated it, they found the candidate-facing experience wasn't as strong as they needed. If you're already on HotSchedules, try the ATS module first. If it works, great. If the sourcing or candidate engagement feels weak, we'd love to show you what we've built."

### Objection: "Fourth has labour forecasting tied to hiring. You don't."

**Response:** "You're right — labour forecasting tied to headcount planning is Fourth's unique strength, and if that's critical to your operations, Fourth is probably the right choice. But most mid-market operators we talk to don't forecast labour at that level of sophistication. They know they need to hire 10 servers for summer or 3 kitchen porters for the weekend, and they need to fill those roles fast. If you're doing demand-driven labour planning at Fourth's level, you're probably already an enterprise operator and we're not the right fit. But if you just need a hiring tool that works, we're a lot simpler and a lot cheaper."

### Objection: "What if we grow and need Fourth's full platform later?"

**Response:** "Fair concern. Lapam-ATS scales to 500+ locations on the same architecture — there's no technical ceiling. But if you hit a scale where you need labour forecasting, integrated payroll, and PEO services, you'll probably outgrow us and move to Fourth or Harri. That's fine. The question is: do you need that today? If you're a 10-location group with no dedicated TA team and a £500/month budget, Fourth's platform is overbuilt for you right now. Use us until you outgrow us, then graduate to Fourth when you hit enterprise scale. We're not trying to be your forever tool — we're trying to solve your hiring problem today."

## Competitive Intelligence

### What Fourth Does Next

- Fourth may unbundle the ATS module and offer it standalone at mid-market pricing to defend against Lapam-ATS — monitor product announcements
- May invest in candidate-facing UX and mobile application experience to close the sourcing gap — watch for mobile app updates
- May build seasonal talent pool CRM if enough hospitality customers request it — monitor UK ATS release notes

### What to Watch

- **HotSchedules customers evaluating ATS modules:** Operators already on HotSchedules who discover the ATS module is underdeveloped are high-intent prospects for Lapam-ATS
- **Mid-market operators priced out:** Operators who contact Fourth sales and receive enterprise pricing quotes that exceed their budget
- **Seasonal operators frustrated with Fourth:** If Fourth cannot deliver seasonal CRM, this is a switching trigger